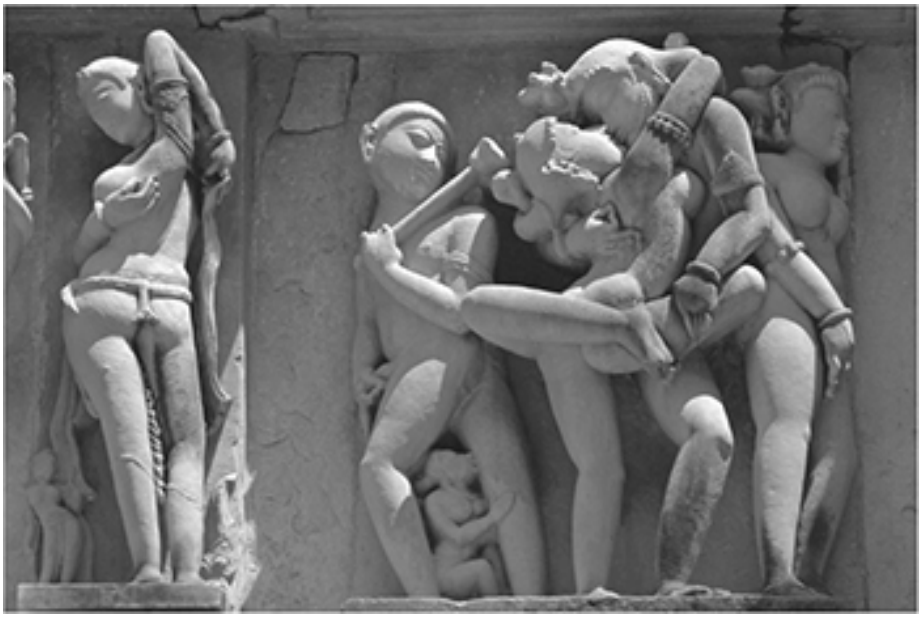


Figure 3. Lakshman Temple panel

Among the worst sources to learn from are the ‘official guides’ outside Khajuraho. They mostly peddle silly or half-baked stories about the erotica. The most ludicrous—and perhaps why the most common— story goes like this: It was an age of war and a lot of men had died. The rest were turning in droves to *sanyaas*, or asceticism, and a life in the forest (in another variant, the men were turning in droves to Buddhist monasticism, never mind that Buddhism was practically non-existent in the Chandela realm and that Hinduism’s own Adi Shankara and his mathas were driving much of the renunciatory monasticism across India at this time). This mortified the Chandelas—if people stopped procreating, society would collapse. ‘Big problem!’ exclaims one guide. So the wise Chandela kings hatched an ingenious plan to ambush these unsuspecting men with erotica when they piously came to visit the temples. The titillation would raise their interest in sex and save society; and, a beaming guide reveals, the ploy evidently worked!

Another common story, a guide relates, is that the sculptors, as an act of artistic freedom, imagined the temple as the world and depicted all of life on its walls—the good, the bad and the ugly—leaving it to the discerning